



copy me either, but he still tries to.

You say your technique is very self-made. How much of your success is purely talent and how much is due to hard work?

I would say it was a balance of both. Some athletes worked just as hard as I did but were not able to jump as high. And I have also known athletes with enormous talent who did not work as hard, and as a result, did not achieve the same results.

Did you always want to be a high jumper?

When I was very young, I was actually afraid of jumping. I was afraid of heights. I started around 10 or 11, and at first, I did not want to do the high jump simply because of that fear.

I was a kid like everyone else. I played a lot and went to school. Around the age of 10, I became serious about sports. In Cuba, there is a lot of emphasis on physical education, and that helps. Many of us love baseball more than other sports, but from a young age, I wanted to be

an athlete. The sports I really enjoyed were running and the hurdles. I also liked the triple jump a lot.

In Cuba, athletics education means you have to try different disciplines. It turned out that I was good at the high jump, and when I was around 14 or 15, I decided to specialise in it.

How hard is it to be an athlete in Cuba, given the number of sanctions on your country?

In the 1980s, when I started, there were sanctions on Cuba, just as there are even now. Back then, though, despite the challenges, they did not completely close the door on us. I was able to compete in the United States many times. Today, it is much more complicated for Cuban athletes because visas are often denied. In my time, I did not face that kind of refusal.

In those days, there was also much stronger government support because we had greater resources. Countries like Russia and East Germany used to extend significant support, including financial help. Now our economic conditions are such

Timeless record: Javier Sotomayor, the 1992 Olympic high jump champion and holder of the enduring 2.45m world record, said records are not built on any single formula.

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that sport cannot receive the same level of backing as it once did.

The international situation is also difficult for us. Our athletes across age groups get far less international exposure than before. Earlier, even youth athletes were able to travel and compete abroad. The positive change today is that athletes receive a larger share of the prize money they earn overseas or through sponsorships. The personal financial return is higher.

Despite all the challenges, Cuba has consistently performed better than most countries in world athletics for a nation of its size. Why do you think that is?

I think the results of Cuban sports infrastructure are there for everyone to see. There was talent scouting